

Adolescents' digital lives: Introduction to the special issue

1 | ADOLESCENTS' DIGITAL LIVES

The key message of this Special issue is that a more nuanced understanding and specification of digital technology use is needed, to gain a comprehensive understanding of adolescent's lives in a digital age (Livingstone, 2024). The digital context is rapidly increasing in the lives of adolescents and across society. Whereas a few decades ago, the digital activity of adolescents was constrained to television and earlier forms of computing and instant messaging on mobile phones, today sees adolescents engaging with a much wider set of digital activities and devices. The time spent on these devices is of great interest to researchers, as is what adolescents do on their devices. This activity sets new parameters for the digital context, making it more diverse and time consuming than ever before. Furthermore, the digital context in which adolescents develop spills over into the offline world. Interactions and interests forged in the online and digital world continue in the offline world, and aspects of the digital world are talked about and influence offline interactions and activity. In this perspective, the digital context is interwoven into the offline world, and it is hard to separate the two.

To begin to understand this complex new reality, we need to consider differences in adolescents' characteristics (such as their age, social background interests and social and emotional capacities), the contexts in which they use digital tools, and the digital technologies themselves that can comprise different apps, networks and different regulations of their usage. Drawing on evidence from different data sources, the studies included in this special issue examine interactions between adolescent social and emotional wellbeing when using different digital technologies, as well as the role of parents, peers and teachers in shaping these interactions and associated outcomes. The findings suggest that the use of digital technology can in some instances be beneficial and in other instances detrimental for adolescent development, depending on characteristics of the individual, the context in which they use these technologies, and the different technologies used.

A number of papers focused on associations between the use of digital technologies and well-being. A 7-day diary study by Scott et al. (2024) among Australian adolescents showed differences in the use of digital technologies for emotion regulation and their effectiveness depending on adolescents' emotional wellbeing (measured by indicators of emotional problems and loneliness). The question of whether socially anxious young people perceive social media as a less risky context than face-to-face interactions to express emotions in communication with their peers was addressed in the study by Angelini et al. (2024). Based on a sample of 1046 Italian students the findings suggested a potentially beneficial role of social media for those who are more socially anxious. In particular the absence of nonverbal cues (such as tone of voice or eye contact) was associated with a higher level of satisfaction with online communication among socially anxious students, while students with lower socially anxiety were more reliant on nonverbal cues.

Social interaction skills were also the topic of the study by Lamash et al. (2024) who developed an online questionnaire to measure adolescents' social interaction skills regarding both in-person and social media interactions and established their significant association with subjective wellbeing. The study by Van de Castele et al. (2024) identified satisfaction of basic psychological needs for autonomy, competence, and relatedness both offline and online as significant predictors of adolescent mental health, although offline need satisfaction played a more crucial role in their samples of adolescents and in particular among emerging adults in Belgium.

Another set of studies address the role of interventions to support adaptive use of digital technologies. The study by Favini et al. (2024) evaluated the effectiveness of pilot school-based interventions to tackle online addictive behaviors in a sample of 462 Italian 14–16 year olds. Results confirmed the short-term effectiveness of their intervention, in particular a significant buffering effect of self-regulatory self-efficacy beliefs, highlighting the importance to develop relevant agentic behaviors among young people to reduce online problematic behaviors.

In a sample of 1018 Austrian adolescents Strohmeier et al. (2024) addresses the digital gender gap. Results showed that girls had lower digital career aspirations and were less likely to have access to a laptop than a smartphone, compared with boys. Interventions enhancing girls' digital self-efficacy beliefs and media appraisal are identified as potential leverage to close this digital gender gap, while parental or teacher's behavior showed no significant association with digital career aspirations.

The role of parents was also the topic of the study by Bradt et al. (2024). Using data of 1651 Belgian adolescents, this study showed that the perceived degree of restrictive mediation as such was not strongly associated with problematic video gaming

and gambling. The perceived style of parents to communicate restrictive mediation seems to have stronger associations with these outcomes, with a controlling style being related to more gaming-related problems than an autonomy-supportive style. A mixed method study conducted with German parent-adolescent dyads (Kurock et al., 2024) showed small to moderate associations between parent and adolescent reported quality of parental support with adolescents' request for help being an additional indicator for the quality of support and possible co-construction support processes. Moreover, the study by Menabo et al. (2024) showed that peer networks and school connectedness were significant influences in mediating the impact of victimization and cybervictimization on the wellbeing of 10–14-year-old students in Italy, highlighting the role of school-related factors in tackling cyberbullying.

Turning to the role of the wider social context in adolescents' digital lives, Hensums et al. (2024) examined the role of YouTube vloggers as socialization figures during the Covid-19 pandemic, showing that their (non)compliance with lockdown measures impacts the attitudes of adolescents who strongly identified with them encouraging either risky or healthy behaviors. The longitudinal study by Bobba et al. (2024) showed how the media salience of the Russia-Ukraine war influenced adolescent ethnic prejudice regarding Ukrainians compared to other ethnic minority groups in Italy showing that prejudice levels decreased over time for all ethnic groups, in particular regarding Ukrainians.

The rich evidence reported in the studies of this special issue are drawn upon in a general discussion by Livingstone (2024). Livingstone offers further reflections on the meaning of 'the digital' and the need for new and inter-disciplinary research directions to better understand the multiple facets of 'the digital' as tools or devices, as space or environment, and as social infrastructure. Livingstone's expert perspective harmonizes with our view of adolescent development in the digital context as being much more than simply the amount of time that adolescents' use their devices or what they do on their devices on a daily or weekly basis.

2 | THE ORIGIN OF THIS SPECIAL ISSUE

All of the papers in this special issue are based on conference presentations at the 18th Biennial Conference of the European Association for Research on Adolescence (EARA). The conference took place August 24–27, 2022 in Dublin, Ireland. The conference theme was *Diverse and Digital*, directing participants' attention towards the importance of the increasing diversity of beliefs, behaviors, and cultures within a world that is, comprised of an increasing mixture of online and offline social interactions. Approximately five hundred people attended the conference, which comprised a day of pre-conference workshops and 81 parallel sessions.

Adolescents' digital lives were discussed in many aspects of the conference. Sonia Livingstone gave a keynote address on how the challenges of adolescence are amplified in a digital world, and how we can design better digital (or other) solutions for their well-being. Ian Power from SpunOut. that is, gave a keynote for practitioners that explored existing digital ecosystems of support informed by adolescents' daily needs. Other keynote talks addressed adolescent diversity, puberty, context, the transition to adulthood, and psychological practice. Throughout the program, many papers and posters presented the results of research on adolescent development and the digital context. As a consequence of the conference theme and interest from speakers and participants, EARA decided to organize a special issue focusing on adolescents' digital lives.

All presenters at the EARA conference who contributed papers and posters on adolescents' digital lives were invited to submit abstracts for this special section. From 21 submitted abstracts, the guest editors selected a shortlist of 12 abstracts with high interrater reliability (intraclass correlation = 0.89). Selection was based on a set of criteria decided a priori, including the abstract being based on the 2022 conference program (origin), the topic matching the theme of this special issue, strong conceptualization of concepts and research questions, clear hypotheses (content), credibility and method fitting in with the research questions (method), promising results and clear tables of figures (results), insightful discussion with attention for practical, clinical or policy implications (discussion). Authors of selected abstracts then prepared and submitted their papers, of which 11 finally made it to this special section, after a thorough and blind review process.

Overall, the studies that comprise this special issue use strong designs and studies to understand adolescents' digital life better. As editors, we are delighted to contribute to this by presenting this special issue in *Journal of Adolescence*.

KEYWORDS

Adolescence, digital, EARA, Internet, social change

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